



How to access a shared folder in VirtualBox?

Asked 11 years ago Modified 5 months ago Viewed 1.2m times



I followed the steps for sharing folders between Windows 7 and Ubuntu in VirtualBox.

244

Despite that the folder appears with a X sign and gives me the following message when a try to open it:



The folder content could not be displayed



When I choose **Shared Folder** from the VirtualBox **Device** menu, the following warning is displayed:

On the system page, you have assigned more than 50% of your computer's memory (2.93 GB) to the virtual machine...

How can I successfully share folders between Windows and Ubuntu using VirtualBox?

virtualbox

shared-folders

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edited Sep 7, 2015 at 22:58



J0e3gan

103 ● 6

asked Jul 9, 2012 at 22:45



userInThisWorld

2,575 ● 3 ● 16 ● 11

Note that you cannot share symlinks! – Joel Sjögren Sep 3, 2018 at 10:23

10 Answers

Sorted by:

Highest score (default)



Access to shared folders in Virtual Box

220 **Command line**



By default, VirtualBox shared folders are created with read/write permission for the guest. This can be done from the command line **on the host** with:



```
VBoxManage sharedfolder add "VM name" --name sharename --hostpath "C:\test"
```



By adding the option `--readonly` we can restrict these for read-only access. Use the `--transient` option if you only want the shares to appear in the present session but not persistent for following sessions. There are some limitations for shared folders (see [this question](#) for details). If prerequisites are met we may mount these shared folders manually by running the following commands in the guest:

```
mkdir /home/<user>/vboxshare
sudo mount -t vboxsf -o uid=1000,gid=1000 sharename /home/<user>/vboxshare
```

Of course, we can also use different mount options to mount as read/only or mount with read access only to root.

Auto-Mount through Virtual Box Manager

In case we enabled auto-mounting on creating a shared folder from the Virtual Box Manager those shared folders will automatically be mounted in the guest with mount point

`/media/sf_<name_of_folder>`. **To have access to these folders users in the guest need to be a member of the group `vboxsf`.**

```
sudo usermod -aG vboxsf $USER
```

The guest **will need to restart** to have the new group added.

Source and further reading: [Virtual Box User Manual](#)

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edited Mar 1 at 17:14



B_San

3 ● 3

answered Jul 10, 2012 at 8:02



Takkat

141k ● 54 ● 308 ● 426

18 i set a shared folder in the GUI and also set the Auto-Mount. restarted the VM, went to `/media` but still nothing there – [amphibient](#) Aug 19, 2013 at 20:11

2 @amphibient @laike9m I had to restart the VM to see the folder in `/media/` – [David_G](#) Apr 4, 2016 at 0:53

9 This command, suggested by another answer here, seems clearer and has better output: `sudo adduser your_username vboxsf` – [Jordan Brough](#) Aug 14, 2017 at 14:28 ✎

1 @JordanBrough: totally correct - all ways lead to Rome. You can even use a graphical frontend `users-admin`. The command was edited in by another user. – [Takkat](#) Aug 14, 2017 at 17:40

Thanks for your answer.. in the command you mentioned above `sudo mount -t vboxsf -o uid=1000,gid=1000 share /home/<user>/vboxshare`, I don't see a mention of the `sharename`, which is used when creating the shared folder using `VBoxManage sharedfolder add "VM name" --name "sharename" --hostpath "C:\test"`. If there are multiple shared folders.. how does VirtualBox know which `sharename` to associate the folder `vboxshare` with? Or do you mean that `sharename` should be the same as `vboxshare`? – [alpha_989](#) Jul 2, 2018 at 16:44



Actually there is an easy way to do that:

147



1. Install the extension pack for VirtualBox.
2. Restart your virtual machine
3. Install Guest Additions in your guest Ubuntu

- You can mount the ISO which is on `/media` or press `Left Control` + `D`

4. Reboot
5. Try to access `/media/sf_your_shared_folder_name`. If you still don't have access, that means you don't belong to the `vboxsf` group. Run this command in the virtual machine:

```
sudo adduser your_vm_username vboxsf
```

6. Log out and log in again to apply changes of `adduser`. If you still can not access the folder, try rebooting.
7. If you still can not see the shared folder, you have to mount it. You can activate automount for the shared folder in the options of VirtualBox Manager.
8. Restart again.

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edited Dec 28, 2021 at 9:17



Asclepius

Asclepius 940 ● 1 ● 7 ● 14

answered Feb 5, 2014 at 12:16



tataogg

tataogg 1,570 ● 1 ● 9 ● 5

- 9 THIS. I wasn't in the user group. Seems like that should have been automated by the guest additions or at least stated clearly. – [AwokeKnowing](#) Jun 17, 2014 at 0:39
- 1 seems the problem for me is that my username is not root. That should have been mentioned somewhere – [AwokeKnowing](#) Jun 17, 2014 at 0:47
- 24 IMPORTANT: You must reboot the computer after calling `adduser`. – [kol](#) Jan 17, 2015 at 15:04
- 5 @[kol](#) No, you need only to log out and log in again. – [Atcold](#) Sep 12, 2015 at 23:41

@Atcold Logging out and in again adds the group to the current user (session) but did not trigger automount of the shared folder in my case. Only a reboot did. – [scai](#) Oct 30, 2016 at 12:27



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First, please make sure you have installed the Guest Additions

1. Start your VM
2. Devices > Insert Guest Additions CD image...  [Insert Guest Additions CD image...](#)
3. Mount the CD:

```
sudo mount /dev/cdrom /media/cdrom
```

4. Install the necessary packages:

```
sudo apt-get install make gcc linux-headers-$(uname -r)
```

5. Install:

```
sudo /media/cdrom/VBoxLinuxAdditions.run
```

Second, add your user to the group 'vboxsf':

```
~$ echo $USER;
ahmed
~$ sudo usermod -a -G vboxsf ahmed
```

Reboot

Know that the label of your shared folder is `lpi` (for example):

 [Edit shared folder](#)

Prepend `sf_` to the label. Then, you will find your shared folder under `/media/sf_lpi`

Finally, you can also create a link to your home. For example:

```
ln -s /media/sf_lpi /home/ahmed/lpi
```

:)

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edited Nov 28, 2016 at 1:06



wjandrea
wjanc 14.1k ● 4 ● 48 ● 98

answered Sep 30, 2015 at 2:43



Abdenour TOUMI
Abde 9,107 ● 9 ● 44 ● 51

Can I use a shared folder from an Ubuntu VM without a harddisk image, but with only a Live CD image? Basically I am trying to add two CD drives, one holding the Ubuntu Live CD, and the other one holding the VBGuestAdditions.iso, and start the machine, then install VBGuestAdditions in the loopback root, and then I would like to be able to access a shared folder. – [Sorin Postelnicu](#) Sep 27, 2017 at 15:37

Also, is there a way to see the shared-folder before mounting, such as by using a command like *lsblk* or something? – [Sorin Postelnicu](#) Sep 27, 2017 at 15:46 

When I try to do "sudo mount -t vboxsf mysharename mysharemountpoint", I always get: "/sbin/mount.vboxsf: mounting failed with the error: No such device" – [Sorin Postelnicu](#) Sep 27, 2017 at 15:51



Add the shared folder to the virtual machine using vBox graphical interface Make sure to select *automount* and *make permanent*

24

Login to the virtual machine using a root account



Check vboxsf group exists



```
~$ grep vboxsf /etc/group
vboxsf:x:125:
```

Check user is not already in vboxsf group

```
~$ id nilo
uid=1000(nilo) gid=1000(nilo)
groups=1000(nilo),4(adm),24(cdrom),27(sudo),30(dip),46(plugdev),109(lpadmin),124(sambashare)
```

Add user nilo to vboxsf group

```
~$ sudo usermod -a -G vboxsf nilo
```

Check again user groups

```
~$ id nilo
uid=1000(nilo) gid=1000(nilo)
groups=1000(nilo),4(adm),24(cdrom),27(sudo),30(dip),46(plugdev),109(lpadmin),124(sambashare),125
```

Reboot and login as nilo

Shared folder is now accesible in `/media/sf_dropbox` (dropbox is the name I gave to the share)

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edited Apr 7, 2014 at 18:56

answered Feb 1, 2014 at 11:28



Chris Moschini



NiloVelez

Reboot worked for me! – [Tarik](#) Sep 16, 2017 at 7:42



17



Share a folder between Host OS-> Windows and Guest OS ->Ubuntu(Virtual box)

Step 1 Install install Guest Additions from VirtualBox's menu go to Devices->Install Guest Additions This will mount a virtual CD on your /media/cdrom. As root user Open this /media/cdrom added folder using Open with terminal option(Right click with mouse).

Step 2 Run the program VBoxLinuxAdditions.run. When the program completes reboot your VirtualBox.

```
$ sudo ./VBoxLinuxAdditions.run
```

Step 3 Create a shared folder. From Virtual menu go to Devices->Shared Folders then add a new folder in the list, this folder should be the one in windows which you want to share with Ubuntu(Guest OS). Make this created folder auto-mount. Example -> Make a folder on Desktop with name Ubuntushare and add this folder.

Step 4 When done with you shared folder(s) specification, we mount folder from Ubuntu(Guest OS). Create a mountpoint, this a directory in Ubuntu that will share files with the shared folder from Windows. Run this to create a directory in Ubuntu

```
$ sudo mkdir ~/Desktop/windowsshare
```

Step 5 With your mountpoint created you can now mount the shared folder. Run this command to share the folder:

```
$ sudo mount -t vboxsf Ubuntushare ~/Desktop/windowsshare
```

Ubuntushare is the name of folder we add in VirtualBox Devices section this folder is in Windows(Host OS). ~/Desktop/windowsshare is the directory in Ubuntu(Guest OS)

CONGRATULATIONS-> Now you can share the files between Windows and Ubuntu. Try adding any file in windows(Host OS) Ubuntu share folder now check Ubuntu(Guest OS) windowsshare directory the file will be reflected.

My Article

[Shared folder b/w windows and ubuntu](#)

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edited Jan 22, 2018 at 9:26

answered Sep 28, 2017 at 19:20



As of now (version 6.0.10 of VirtualBox) there are `make permanent` and `auto-mount` options for shared folder, also `mount point` (At) in GUI of virtualbox. For me the following worked:

7



1. On guest Ubuntu: `sudo apt-get install virtualbox-guest-utils`
2. Add shared folder in GUI of VirtualBox.
3. Restart guest OS



Folder on mount point specified in GUI was created automatically and `ls` showed files located on host Windows PC.

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answered Sep 2, 2019 at 14:55



Alex Martian
582 ● 5 ● 12

- 1 Running the sudo command created vboxsf inside of my Virtualbox! – Climbs_lika_Spyder Jul 1, 2020 at 20:47

Thank you. After updating Ubuntu, my shared folders showed up empty. After installing this package and re-adding them they showed what they were meant to. – Arthur Bowers Jan 24, 2022 at 13:12



Late to the party, but here is the solution that worked well for me:

6



1. Make sure that you have **Guest Additions** installed
 - And all the necessary packages: `linux-headers`, `build-essential`, `gcc`, `make` ...
2. Add **Shared folder**
 - In VirtualBox Manager select your Virtual Machine (VM)
 - Settings >> Shared Folders >> Add new shared folder
 - Folder path: path to the folder to be shared with your VM
 - Folder name: name of the shared folder to be displayed in your VM
 - Tick the **Auto-mount** option, so that it automatically mounts the folder on VM startup
3. After adding a shared folder, your folder appears in your VM as `sf_<folder_name>`
 - Problem is that you **cannot access** it unless you are logged in as `root` user
4. **Give permissions** to the shared folder. Open terminal (`Ctrl` + `Alt` + `T`) and enter these commands:

```
sudo usermod -a -G vboxsf <username>
```

```
sudo chown -R <username>:users /media/sf_<folder_name>
```

- where `<username>` - your user name, `<folder_name>` - shared folder name
- What these commands do is:
 1. adds a user to `vboxsf` group
 2. changes the ownership of the shared folder (it's all files and subdirectories) to the user

5. Restart your VM

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answered Apr 4, 2021 at 21:42

 **GooDeeJAY**
GooD 176 ● 1 ● 6

-
- 1 This worked perfectly in VirtualBox 6.1.32 with an Ubuntu 20.04.3 LTS guest VM. – **dan** Jan 31, 2022 at 16:11
-



3



1. Install the program called 'Programs and Group' from the Software Center
2. Choose the current user and click on Manage Groups
3. Choose vboxsf and click 'Add'
4. Reboot



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answered Mar 8, 2013 at 19:08

 **Mohamad A. Hasan**
31 ● 3

Could not find in software center Mint 17.1 but menu had users and groups, is this it?? – **russ_hensel** Sep 26, 2016 at 14:55

@russ_hensel Mint is not an official Ubuntu flavour. Ask your question at [Unix & Linux](#) instead. – **wjandrea** Nov 28, 2016 at 0:49



2



1. Create a dir where you're going to mount this, like `mkdir docs`
2. Install Guest Additions into the guest Ubuntu machine.
3. Shutdown the Ubuntu guest, then configure it.
4. In Storage, setup your shared folder and make a note of what you set as the name in the second field. For example "crazy". Check the box for Auto-Mount.
5. Boot the Ubuntu guest.



6. Like you said, it won't actually be accessible. (This is the key part of your question.) You'll find instead it is present at `/media/sf_crazy`, where 'crazy' is the name you gave it. And, it will also be present in your home dir at `~/crazy`.
7. You now need to take one more step to actually mount it:

```
sudo mount -o uid=1000,gid=1000 -t vboxsf ~/crazy ~/docs
```

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edited Nov 28, 2016 at 1:08



wjandrea

wjanc 14.1k ● 4 ● 48 ● 98

answered Jun 28, 2016 at 14:55



Chris Moschini

153 ● 4



Perform these steps after installing Guest Additions. For Windows 10 host environment, on the Windows machine I had to share folders.

1

1. Right click folder to share



2. Select "Share with"

3. Select "Specific People"



4. Chose Everyone, read/write options



5. On client Ubuntu machine run command: `sudo adduser xxxxxxx vboxsf`

where xxxxxx is your user account name. Log out and log back in to Ubuntu.

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edited Sep 8, 2019 at 12:57



Kristopher Ives

Kristo 5,399 ● 2 ● 27 ● 36

answered Jun 14, 2017 at 19:21



user3889404

11 ● 1



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